Hir and Swing-Set

By Alysia Harris and Aysha El-Shamayleh / Andrea Gibson

INTRODUCTION

Everyone has to go through hard times in life and that's what makes us all equal. Everyone can relate to sitting in front of someone they love and not knowing what to say for fear of being judged. This is what's wrong in the world. People are afraid to be who they are because they are afraid of what OTHER people will think of them.

In Hir by Alysia Harris and Aysha El-Shamayleh, we see a student . . . withdrawn, silent, alone . . . afraid of being judged . . . afraid of being true to herself or is it himself?

In the hope that knowledge will lead to understanding, I've chosen poetry about acceptance. The voices of these poets are honest, authentic and need to be heard.

HIR by Alysia Harris and Aysha El-Shamayleh

Melissa sits in the back of the classroom afraid to speak up.

She pulls awkwardly at her extra loose khaki cargo pants.

She doesn't want the boys to notice her.

James finds himself at the back of a classroom.

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His baseball cap casts a shadow on his pimple-stained forehead.

A wide shirt hangs on his broad shoulders,

But no one ever noticed him.

Melissa,

The teacher asks,

And she says nothing because she is not here,

And Melissa has never been here,

Because Melissa is just some abstract jumble of syllables that doesn't fit her position.

She is not what she seems,

She doesn't want to have to explain to her mother for the 232nd time why she doesn't want to

wear a dress to prom,

Doesn't paint her face, it's 'cause her whole body is painted on.

Melissa, Melissa.

James doesn't want to have to explain where he came from,

'Cause with the exception of Melissa he has been deemed

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an abstract reality by everyone.

All he wishes for is to get to wear a tuxedo to prom.
And Melissa's been tucking in breasts that'll be growing for three years now,
Been using duct tape to press them down and mold them more into pecs.
She just wishes that people would understand that at birth her genitals didn't know which way to
grow,
Mad at God who couldn't relay a message directly to her hormones that they should produce
more testosterone.
The only person who understands her is James,
And they have been playmates since the age of four,
Around the time girls notice boys and boys notice girls.
See, James' family wanted daughters instead of sons,
And Melissa was always like that male beetle that everyone called a ladybug.

Melissa, Melissa, where is she?

Sometimes she wishes she could rip the skin off her back,

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Every moment of everyday she feels trapped in the flesh of a stranger.

Melissa.

As she stands to her feet wanting to say

"I'm here, and I've been here since I was born, so quit asking me if I'm a him or a her,
'Cause when you combine the two pronouns you get H.I.R,
Hir,
And God combined the two genders and put me in this body transgendered.
I'm here, so quit talking about me like I'm not here."

James falls back into Melissa's skin,
And the two comfort each other in syncopated heartbeats,
Waiting for the day when Melissa can finally scrub off this made up genetic makeup,
When the teacher asks for James, and he can say
"I'm here."

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Alysia Harris and Aysha El-Shamayleh
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This Educational Material from the Book Unheard Voices can be found at
https://www.yumpu.com/en/document/read/27382894/hir-by-alysia-harris-and-aysha-el-shamayleh-anti-defamation-

TRANSITION

It's that simple . . . "I am here." Be true to yourself . . . accept who you are and expect that others will also. It's that simple. But also, so very difficult . . .

These poems are about gender identification, but accepting who you are isn't limited to this situation. Whether you are coming out, telling people you are getting a divorce, you are pregnant, or even that you are dying; it is key that you make it known and be true to yourself . . .

Remember, there is no harder, there's just hard. Everyone has their own closet, and a closet is no place for someone to be living. It's that simple. . . once you've accepted yourself.

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Swing-Set by Andrea Gibson

"Are you a boy or a girl?"
he asks, staring up at me in all three feet of his pudding face grandeur, and I say "Dylan,
you've been in this class for three years and you still don't know if I'm a boy or a girl?"
"Uh-uh."
"Well, at this point, I don't really think it matters, do you?"
"Uhm, no.
Can I have a push on the swing?"
And this happens every day.
It's a tidal wave of kindergarten curiosity rushing straight for the rocks of me, whatever I am.

In the class, when we discuss the Milky Way galaxy, the orbit of the Sun around the Earth or whatever.
Jupiter, Saturn, Mars, and kids, do you know that some of the stars we see when we look up in the sky are so far away, they've already burned out?
What do you think of that?
Timmy?

"Uh my mom says that even though you got hairs that grow from your legs, and the hairs on your head grow short and poky, and that you smell really bad, like my dad, that you're a girl."
"Thank you, Timmy."
And so it goes.

On the playground, she peers up at me from behind her pink power puff sunglasses and then asks, "Do you have a boyfriend?"
And I say no, and she says "Oh… do you have a girlfriend?"
And I say "No, but if by some miracle, twenty years from now, I ever finally do, then I'll definitely bring her by to meet you. How's that?"
"Okay. Can I have a push on the swing?"
And that's the thing.
They don't care.
They don't care. Us, on the other hand.
My father sitting across the table at Christmas dinner, gritting his teeth over his still-full plate, his appetite raped away by the intrusion of my haircut,

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"What were you thinking? You used to be such a pretty girl!"

Frat boys, drunken, screaming, leaning out of the windows of their daddys' SUVs,
"Hey! Are you a faggot or a dyke?"
And I wonder what would happen if I met up with them in the middle of the night.

Then of course there's always the somehow not-quite-bright enough fluorescent light of the public restroom, "Sir! Sir, do you realize this is the ladies' room?"
"Yes, ma'am, I do . . . "

But the best, the best is always the mother at the market, sticking up her nose while pushing aside her daughter's wide eyes, whispering "Don't stare, it's rude."
And I want to say, "Listen, lady, the only rude thing I see is your paranoid parental hand pushing aside the best education on self that little girl's ever gonna get,
living with your Maybelline lipstick after hips and pedi kiwi, vanilla-smelling beauty;

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so why don't you take your pinks and blues, your boy-girl rules and shove them in that car with your issue of Cosmo, because tomorrow, I start my day with twenty-eight minds who know a lot more than you.
And if I show up in a pink frilly dress, those kids won't love me any more, or less."

"Hey, are you a boy or a — never mind, can I have a push on the swing?"
And some day, y'all, when we grow up, it's all gonna be that simple.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Andrea Gibson
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AWARD HISTORY

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